

Narrative 1	Narrative 2
Genesis 4:3-16 • Cain murders his brother • Abel's innocent blood "cries out from the ground"	Genesis 6:5-6, 11-12 ⁵ and Yahweh saw that multiplied was the badness of humanity in the land, and every purpose (מחשבת) of the plans of his heart was only bad all the day , ⁶ and Yahweh regretted (נחם) that he made humanity in the land, and he was pained in his heart .
Genesis 4:17-26 • Cain's city • Lemek murders without mercy	¹¹ And the land was ruined (שחת) before Elohim, and the land was filled with violence (חמס), ¹² and Elohim saw the land: and behold, it was ruined (נשחת) , for all flesh had ruined (שחת) its/his way upon the land.
<i>Violence in the Land Preceding Genesis 6:5-6, 11-12. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>	

Yahweh's decision is one of grief, sadness, and emotional pain. He must respond to the outcry of innocent blood when it soaks the land, so he enacts a decree to purify the land of the defilement of bloodshed. This is a key pattern that runs throughout the Hebrew Bible.

Numbers 35:33-34 NASB

³³ So you shall not **pollute the land** in which you are; for **blood pollutes the land** and no **purification can be made for the land for the blood that is shed on it**, except by the blood of him who shed it. ³⁴ So you shall not **defile the land** in which you live, in the midst of which I dwell; for I the LORD am dwelling in the midst of the sons of Israel.

Two Divine Warnings About the Flood (Gen. 6:13-7:5)

God's speech to Noah comes in two parallel panels that overlap and differ in the way that Hebrew poetic lines do.

Divine Speech #1: Translation and Literary Design of 6:13-22

Command

¹³ And Elohim said to Noah,

Announcement of the Flood

"The end of **all flesh** has come before me,
because the land is filled with violence because of them,
and behold, I am going to ruin them with the land.

Directions for Deliverance by Making the Ark

- a 14 **Make** for yourself **an ark** of **gopher (גפר)** trees;
b you will **make** **the ark** of reeds,
a' and you will **pitch (כפר)** it inside and out with **pitch (כפר)**.

15 This is how you will **make** it:
300 cubits: the length of **the ark**
50 cubits: its width
30 cubits: its height.

- a 16 You will **make** a window for **the ark**,
b' and you will finish it to a cubit from the top;
a' and you will set the door of **the ark** in its side;
b' with lowers, seconds, and thirds you will **make** it.

Announcement of the Flood

17 **And as for me, behold, I am going to** bring the flood of water upon the land,
to ruin all flesh, which has in it the breath of life, from under the skies,
everything that is on the land will expire.

Directions for Deliverance by Entering the Ark

- a 18 **And I will set up my covenant with you [see 9:8-17]**
b and you will **go** into **the ark**,
c you and your sons and your wife, and your sons' wives with you.
c' 19 And of every living thing of **all flesh**,
b' two of everything you will make **go** into **the ark**,
a **to keep them alive** with you;
b they shall be **male and female**,
c 20 **of the birds after their kind**,
c' **and of the animals after their kind**,
c'' **of every creeping thing of the ground after its kind**,
b' **two of every kind** will **go** to you
a' **to keep them alive**.
a 21 And as for you, take for yourself some of all **edible-food** that you will eat,
b' and gather it to yourself;

a' and it shall be for **edible-food** for yourself and for them."

Fulfillment

22 And Noah did
according to all that Elohim had commanded him,
so he did.

Genesis 6:13-22. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Observations on Speech #1

- The unit begins and ends with a report of command and fulfillment.
- There are two announcements of the flood as a divine initiative, each followed by a call from God to Noah that Noah initiate a response. First to make the ark, the vehicle of his deliverance, and second to fill the ark with his family, the animals, and food.

God's Purpose in Bringing the Flood (Gen. 6:11-13)

As noted in 6:5-7, God's decision to bring the flood was not motivated by anger, but by grief. This portrait is filled out in an important way in 6:11-13, which transitions from the narrative of creation's corruption to God's response and address to Noah.

Point of View	Parallel Statements
Narrator's report of the land's corruption	11 And the land was ruined before Elohim, and the land was filled with violence , 12 and Elohim saw the land: and behold, it was ruined , for all flesh had caused the ruin of its way upon the land.
God's words to Noah recall the narrative report	13 And Elohim said to Noah, "The end of all flesh has come before me, because the land is filled with violence because of them , and behold, I am going to cause their ruin with the land.

God's Purpose in Bringing the Flood. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Note the parallelism between "all flesh has caused the ruin of its way on the land" and "I am going to cause their ruin with the land." This shows that God's decision to bring the flood is interconnected with the disaster that humans are themselves choosing and perpetuating in the land. God's decision is not imposed from the outside. Rather, his decision is prompted by and works through humanity's self-enacted ruin in the land.

The wording of 6:13 is crucial: "The end of all flesh has come up right in front of me."

[God] "is not the subject of the clause ['the end has come'] ... the notion is that the demise of all flesh has passed before [God] and so made itself evident. The Hebrew construction distances the deity from the decision making process, almost as if this outcome was inevitable."

Bandstra, Barry (2008). [*Genesis 1-11: A Handbook on the Hebrew Text*](#). Baylor University Press. 358.

"The [verse] suggests that God has seen where the ruination of creation is headed and has decided to accelerate the process to its completion ... the plain sense of the Hebrew text conveys something very different from most English translations, which are perhaps influenced by the view of an angry, punitive deity. ... The flood was an ancient symbol of destruction and disorder, as so is a fitting medium for the dissolution of creation as it overwhelms every boundary and returns creation to the primordial undifferentiated 'deep' that existed before Yahweh spoke boundaries into being. ... We are left with the sense that God is not so much sending the flood to punish the world as much as facilitating, through the flood, the inevitable descent into chaos caused by human destructiveness and violence. God ruins an already ruined creation, and in so doing creates conditions for a reordering and a renewal to take place."

Hawk, L. Daniel (2018). [*The Violence of the Biblical God: Canonical Narrative and Christian Faith*](#). Eerdmans. 32-33.

Reflection Question

What is God responding to that motivates him to send the flood?

Session 12: Noah the Righteous Remnant

Key Takeaways

- A key concept for understanding the narrative flow of the whole Bible is that the righteousness of one can count for the many. The story of Noah is first time we see this in the Bible.
- The Bible itself provides the questions to interrogate God's character.

Divine Speech #2: Translation and Literary Design of 7:1-5

¹ And Yahweh said to Noah,

“**Go**, **you** and all your household, into **the ark**
for **you** I have seen as a righteous one before me in this generation.

- a ² You will take for yourself
- b **from every pure animal**,
 - c **seven each**, a man and his wife,
 - b' **and from the animal which is not pure**,
 - b' **two each**, a man and his wife,
 - b'' ³ **also from the birds of the skies**,
 - c'' **seven each**, male and female,

- a **to keep alive** seed on the **face of the land**.
- b ⁴ For in **seven days** more,
 - c **I will send rain** on the land
 - b' **forty days** and forty nights;
 - c' **and I will wipe away** every standing-thing that I have made
 - a' from the **face of the land**.”

⁵ And Noah did
according to all that Yahweh had commanded him.

Genesis 7:1-5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).